

- 1. What English elective did you sign up to take in the fall? (I absolutely will not take it personally if you aren't taking my class. It is just sometimes useful to connect my thoughts to what you decided to do as a next step. And, if you are taking my class, I will leave your letter to last so that I can include information from the fall semester.)**

I signed up to take Literary Journalism in the fall.

- 2. What do you plan to study/major in in college? If you don't know, that's totally fine! In that case, what are some things that you are looking forward to having the chance to explore in college?**

I plan to study Electrical Engineering in college.

- 3. What do you enjoy about English (the class or the general subject area)? Note: your answer need not be about my class or anything specific to English class at all – if you love fantasy novels or writing poetry or have been studying linguistics (etc), let me know.**

This one is a little odd for me to write, because if you had asked me a year ago, the only honest answer I could have given would have been “nothing.” English had always been one of those academic areas that I fell into a sort of self-fulfilling prophecy of hatred in my life; from

the start of my Hunter career, there had always been an overcast of irritation whenever I did English assignments. They took a significant amount of deep thinking to write but it was not the deep thinking that I had been accustomed to, in the other aspects of life that presented challenges that could only be overcome through critical thinking.

English took a *personal* level of critical thinking, but for years I had always pushed the “personal” to the side, due to what I thought at first was a rejection of a style of thinking that I thought was “useless,” but what I now see as a personal reaction to a style of thinking that forced me to really consider what I truly valued, because every word that I wrote, every piece of analysis could not be boiled down to a formula, but had to be personal in some way.

But for years, I tried to boil down English, from the class to the entire field writ large into a formula that allowed me to take the personal aspect out of the writing. I remember obsessing over examples that were given by my teachers to find some *formula* that connected every piece of writing into an equation that I could pump out, without thought. I hate to admit that I spent more time looking at other people’s writing than my own, in order to extract some sort of confession from them about why they got such high marks. But of course that didn’t work, because my writing had been using the same part of my brain that cranks out homeworks and study for tests. You could have replaced my writing up to that point with an equation because my thinking up to that point had been an equation, somehow formed from the years of frustration over the broad strokes of the style of thinking that “English” class requires. And so, for years, that’s how the self fulfilling prophecy of why I hated English worked.

I enjoy English now because I discovered, in a roundabout way, why it’s important. This year, I took a new approach to writing in my first few assignments that I never thought would work: I treated it like a debate. A debate, in the sense that I started to imbibe in my writing the

part of my brain that fought for what was right: the part of my brain that makes me enjoy teaching, engineering, and every discipline that requires you to really *care* about the product, whether that be a solution to a problem or a unique way to teach a unique student. I started treating my first drafts like fiery sermons, where I could finally extract *why* I cared about a certain interpretation, rather than trying to determine if it was the “best” interpretation.

My catchphrase to my friends and family used to be “*English class made me hate reading,*” but the truth is I never stopped hating reading books. I still read books, because the allure of them was that I could immerse myself into the author’s point of view and bring something out of it into my life—something that academics didn’t take away from me. All academics did was ask me to actualize the meaning that I so dearly enjoyed from literature into a paper—which I misinterpreted as a challenge to break apart what literature really meant to me: a way to express the personal side of my mind that seems to be beaten down by life.

4. What book, activity, or topic did you find most interesting/significant this year? Why?

I definitely found ... And the Earth did not devour him to be the most interesting story I read this year. This was for a variety of reasons, not the least being that I was coincidentally doing a research piece on the history agricultural labor movements in California for my Global US History class—the Chicano movement drew its origins back directly to the movements I was studying, so it ended up being a convenient (if not a little tiring) novel complementing my knowledge and interests.

But beyond the academic connection I had with the story, I found the novel uniquely fascinating for its emotion: for me, the thing that makes American literature especially special and engaging for me to read is how it allows for stories of conflicting values (economical,

political, religious, etc.) to take hold; in that, I think ...And the Earth did not Devour him is only beaten by The Things They Carried in that regard—with characters being forced to place their values against an entirely foreign culture and/or environment, and somehow creating a synthesis out of it in the end. That is what makes a piece of “American” literature history unique for me, and ...And the Earth did not Devour Him captured that best out of any novel we read this year due to its vignette structure allowing so many unique voices to be captured (although the same can be said about The Things They Carried, it was a close race to see which was my favorite).

5. What paper or project do you think was your best work in my class? Why? Note: it is helpful for me to be able to talk about academic writing. You are welcome to mention personal writing, but in that case you should also point me to a FLE or in-class analysis writing if you can.

My best work has to be my Personal Literary Essay on The Things They Carried. I don't think I have ever before been able to s

6. What paper or project are you most proud of? (if different from above) Why?

I think my most proud writing had to have been my term paper that I did on *100 Years of Solitude*. This was the first time that I had gone out of my way to directly challenge myself in a literature class. I went into my term paper novel completely blind, and I had not read a single other piece of Latin American literature ever.

100 Years of Solitude turned out to be the worst choice for a term paper book I could have made. It was absurdly complex, and I think that only a PhD thesis length of analysis could sufficiently analyze even a single theme of the story properly. To fit an entire, well thought out

analysis into basically five pages turned out to be an impossible task, something I only realised too late.

Even through this pain, I still believe that this was the paper which I was best able to provide a novel, engaging interpretation on

7. In what way(s) do you feel you grew as a reader/writer/thinker this year?

I hope I answered this question in prompt three! My growth can really be boiled down to how I've come to fundamentally approach the act of being a reader, writer, or a thinker. I was stuck in a thinking that I could replace the personal thinking that makes great ideas with a formula to scrape the surface of literature for an answer that even I knew did not have that personal involvement that makes good work.

8. Do you have any outside interests/pursuits that you would like me to mention in my letter or that you think might help me write a stronger letter? (Note that your counselor letter will cover your extracurricular activities in more detail than I will. But it can sometimes be helpful if I can tie what I have seen of you in class to how those abilities/interests/characteristics tie into who you are outside of class.)

One of the things that seems to cling to me, no matter what I do, is that I always find myself in a teaching/mentorship position. I've been teaching in some aspect in every single extracurricular I've done, from the non-profit that I started out as a teacher in and rose to become

the president of, the robotics team that I sought to reform to become completely student-led after being appointed as an engineering teacher and finding the system to be rotten from the inside out, the teaching jobs I've held every single summer. Engineering might be the trade I want to pursue in life, but English has been the class in Hunter which I've truly faced challenge after challenge in, and if you could map my teaching skills to my English skills, I think you would see a one-to-one progression in how I approached both: becoming more personal made me a better English student, and a better teacher.

9. Is there anything else that I should know about you that would help me write a strong letter? (Including, but not limited to: other things you have done in the world of literature/writing [publications, camps, awards, etc.]; other areas of life that you have excelled in or done cool stuff in; particular life challenges that you faced this year [or face generally] while simultaneously navigating the world of school.)

If there's one quote that could describe my time this year, it would be "How did you go bankrupt?" Two ways. Gradually, then suddenly." So much of how I live my life has been in the constant flux of change from the moment I entered Hunter (which is to be expected), from my extracurriculars, my academics, my personal physical and mental health, and so much more, but it all seems to have accelerated all at once in my Junior year (a positive, now that I look back on it). This is the first year that I think I really saw the amount of potential that I have when I break the chains of living my life (both academically and personally) in a formulaic way, the formula

of "success" which I think has been negatively imposed on most in not all Hunter students. I hope that my desire to change the way I fundamentally approach challenges has been shown to you in English class!